

Presidents without Parties: Populism's Hidden Weakness in Elections

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In 2017, France witnessed a political shock. Marine Le Pen – a far-right leader of the National Rally – surprised the public by finishing second in the first round of the presidential election. She beat François Fillon – once seen as the main challenger to Emmanuel Macron, the new centrist rising star, by 21.3% of the vote. But what looked like a surge of momentum for Le Pen stopped here. Just 2 months later, when voters returned to the polls for the National Assembly elections, the National Rally struggled to turn her popularity into the legislative power. The National Rally captured only 13.2% of the first-run vote, and just 120 of its 568 candidates (about 21%) advanced to the runoff. Macron's party, La République En Marche, by contrast, swept forward: with 28.2% of the vote, nearly all of its 466 candidates (454, to be exact) qualified for the second round. Both Le Pen and Macron were charismatic leaders that attract tremendous supports. While Macron's popularity lifted his party to victory, Le Pen's did not translate into legislative strength. The explanation lies in the structure of France's plurality electoral system and the nature of populist ideology itself, which together tend to disadvantage populist parties like Marine Le Pen's National Rally.

The Opportunity and the Disadvantage of Populist Party under Presidentialism

The main differentiation between presidentialism or semi-presidentialism and parliamentarism lies in how the head of state is chosen. In a parliamentary system, the prime ministers come from the party or coalition that wins the majority in parliament. This means the executive and legislative branches are fully connected. In contrast, under presidential systems, the separation of power allows a party to control the executive branch by winning the presidency without holding any seat in parliament. This opens the door for populist parties to capture executive power – but it can also create internal tensions when the president's broad appeal clashes with the ideology of their party.

France's Fifth Republic follows a semi-presidential system, where both the president and legislators are elected separately. To win the presidency, a candidate must either win more than 50% of the vote nation-wide in the first round or defeat their opponent in a second-round runoff between the top two candidates. This two-round structure makes independent and moderate voters – as known as the “median voters” – crucial to victory. Candidates are therefore pushed to move their ideology positions closer to the political center to attract these voters. For mainstream center-right and center-left parties, this strategy is relatively easy since their ideologies already overlap with the middle ground. However, for parties on the far right or far left, this moderation can backfire. When a

strongly ideological candidate softens their message to appeal to the center, they risk creating an ideological gap between themselves and their base – a gap that make it difficult to transfer personal popularity to the party as a whole. Experience from the 2017 and 2022 French general elections suggests that Marine Le Pen and her National Rally faced exactly this problem.

National Rally: From Past to Present

The National Rally (originally the National Front) is a far-right party founded by Jean-Marie Le Pen in 1972. Under his leadership, the party was known for its antisemitic rhetoric, Holocaust denial, and far-right appeal – that earned it attention but limited electoral success. When Marine Le Pen, Jean-Marie’s daughter, took over the leadership in 2011, she set out to change it. Determined to get rid of the image of extremism and “normalize” the party, she launched a rebranding effort to make the party more acceptable to the mainstream.

One of her most striking moves came in 2015, when she [expelled her own father](#) from the party after he described gas chambers as a mere “detail of history”, again in an interview. Marine Le Pen also reframed the party’s message. She adopted liberal-sounding, widely accepted language to argue against immigration – especially from Muslim-majority countries – claiming that Islamist culture threatened French traditions, [gender equality](#), [LGBTQ rights](#), liberal democracy, and even the Jewish community, who were most affected by her father’s antisemitism rhetoric. As a political scientist [Cécile Alduy stated](#): While Jean-Marie paired “immigrants” or “immigration” with words like “danger,” “threat” or “loss,” yielding phrases that scapegoat or even demonize France’s large immigrant population, Marine used more technocratic pairings such as “protection,” “cost,” “euro” or “pay.” This rhetorical shift allowed her to position herself as a defender of French values, attracting the mainstream electorate, even including some feminist, LGBTQ, and Jewish voters.

To complete the image renovation, Marine Le Pen [renamed the party](#) from National Front to National Rally in 2019, explaining: “This name, National Front, bears an epic and glorious history, which no one can deny... But you know it is for many French people a psychological obstacle. We were originally a protest party... There should be no doubt that we can be a ruling party.” She also worked to distance National Rally from other extreme right party in Europe. In 2024, her party and its allies in the European Parliament’s Identity and Democracy (ID) group expelled Germany’s AfD after one member, Maximilian Krah, stated he would “never say that anyone who wore an SS uniform was automatically a criminal.”

Yet, Marine Le Pen’s “normalization” strategy has been only partly successful. Transforming a leader’s image is one thing; changing an entire party is far harder. Party members and

supporters who stick with their original ideology that they thought align with the party's line still make controversial comments in interviews or on social media, undermining the new image she has tried to build. More importantly, the internal friction erodes Le Pen's moderation efforts. Many grassroots members accuse Le Pen of making the party too mainstream. Local representatives complain that national leaders impose a uniform strategy on the local level while ignoring their voice. As scholars [Tobias Böhmelt and his colleagues](#) argue, "Populist parties gravitate toward personalized leaders and thus develop less democratic intra-party structures." Even her father has attacked her "normalization" approach, blaming it for the party's weak results in 2021 local elections. In an interview, [he warned](#), "Either Marine Le Pen finds the tone of previous fights, or else she will gradually fade."

The rise of Éric Zemmour has amplified those warnings. Zemmour – a far-right writer and politician – ran president in 2022, tapping into the segment of voters who felt abandoned by Le Pen's shift to the center. His campaign exposed the ideological space on the extreme right, positioning him as the true representative of "the real people." Several National Rally members even [defected to Zemmour's party](#), frustrated by Le Pen's attempts to normalize the party. To them, National Rally had lost its identity as an anti-establishment, anti-elite party and was turning into just another part of the system.

The Electoral Consequence of the Intra-Party Conflicts

A National Rally politician once said: "When we were too radical, we were told you will never get there, and now that some people find us not radical enough, we are told you never get there." The comment captures the paradox facing populist parties in presidentialism. Marine Le Pen's personal "normalization" strategy may have improved her image among moderate voters, but it also created an ideology gap between herself and her party. This internal divide weakened her ability to turn personal popularity into institutional strength.

Figure 1 and Figure 2 show each party's vote share in 2017 and 2022 presidential and parliamentary elections at the department level (similar to county in the US). The data was collected from [the official website of Ministry of Interior of France](#). Ideally, if a presidential candidate can successfully mobilize voters to support their party, the dots should fall along the 45-degree line. Dots below the line indicate that presidential candidates' vote share exceeded their party's parliamentary vote share.

As we expected, both Figure 1 and Figure 2 show that almost the navy dots – representing National Rally (RN) – fall below the 45-degree line. In other words, more people voted for Le Pen than for National Rally. By contrast, the center-right the Republican party (LR, blue

dots) and center-left Socialist party (PS, red dots) cluster more closely around the line, suggesting a stronger alignment between their presidential and parliamentary performances. Interestingly, in 2017, Macron's party (MDM) even performed better than he

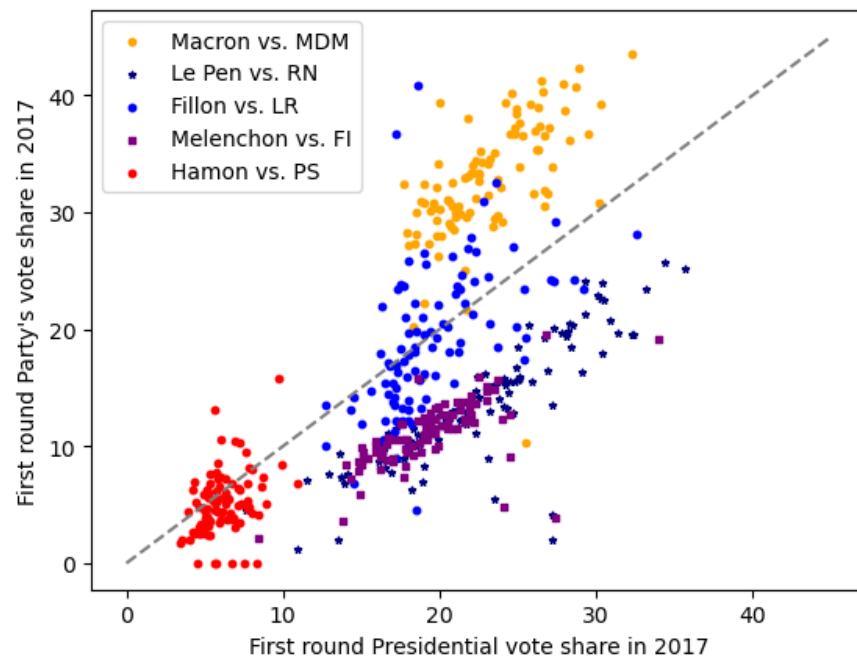


Figure 1: Department-Level Results of Presidential and Parliamentary Election in 2017

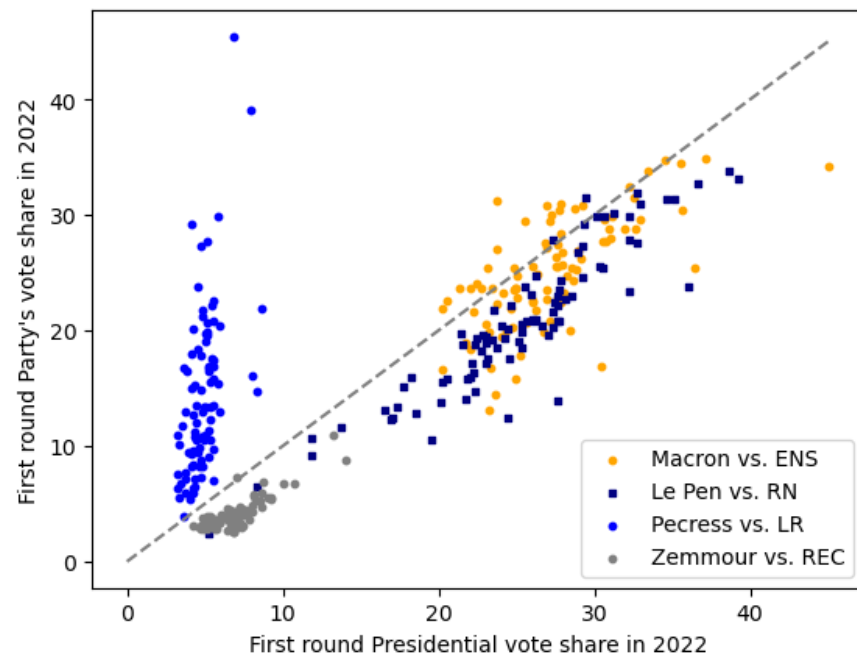


Figure 2: Department-Level Results of Presidential and Parliamentary Election in 2022

did in the parliamentary elections, as shown by orange dots above the line in Figure 1. It is also worth noting that the left-wing populist party La France Insoumise (FI) faced the similar problem in 2017. Its leader, Jean-Luc Mélenchon, drew significant personal support in the presidential race but failed to transfer that momentum to his party in the legislative contest.

Together, these patterns reinforce the idea: populist parties are facing higher risk of an ideology gap their presidential candidates and parties. In majoritarian systems like France's, this gap limits how far populist movements can convert personal charisma into lasting political power.

Populism's Limits: Lessons from France and Beyond

In France, both far-right leader Marine Le Pen and far-left figure Jean-Luc Mélenchon have emerged as major challengers to the political establishment, especially after the 2022 presidential election, when traditional parties suffered serious public distrust. Yet, despite their weak performance in the presidential elections, established parties continue to hold certain advantages in the legislative branch. One key reason lies in the intra-party ideology gap within populist parties themselves. When leaders like Le Pen attempt to broaden their appeal by softening their positions, they risk losing their core supporters—creating internal divisions that weaken their organizational strength.

Looking beyond France, similar patterns appear elsewhere. In the United States, Donald Trump's populist rhetoric has strained his relationship with the Republican Party. In Brazil, Lula da Silva and the Workers' Party are facing their own ideological tensions. And in Taiwan, Kuoyu Han's rise within the Kuomintang (KMT) revealed similar struggles between populist energy and the traditional party appeal. Together, these cases suggest that the intra-party dynamics of populist movements – their partial shifts in ideological position – may be one of the most important, yet overlooked, challenges for populism in modern democracies.